Even Strife Sleeps

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Even Strife Sleeps

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Summary

> Phainon gets sick as hell, everyone overreacts (understandably), Mydei drops increasingly un-subtle sentimental trinkets like a lovesick crow, Aglaea delivers her regular dose of poetic shade, and Tribbie is Tribbie. By the time Phainon's mind clears, he's short a fever, up a bracelet, and still trying to figure out why Strife's god keeps sitting bedside like it's a confessional.

Notes

> Alright, day 5's prompt, gift giving! I'm honestly really excited for tomorrow since the fic I wrote for it I'd say was my second favorite to write for? But yeah, hope you guys enjoy <3333
>
> Y'all believe it or not WE GOT ART FOR THIS YIPPYYYY!!! Check this fanart out I love it😭

See the end of the work for more notes

Phainon drifted somewhere between waking and nothing.

It was difficult to tell where he was, or if time had passed at all. His thoughts felt heavy, unsteady, slipping away each time he tried to grasp them. There was no sense of the world around him, no light or sound, only a dense, muffled quiet that settled over everything.

He tried to remember something—anything—but whatever memories might have lived there stayed just out of reach. There was a name he should have known. A place. A reason. None of it came.

After a while, he noticed the sound.

Distant, blurred voices, like hearing someone speak through thick walls or underwater. He couldn't make out the words, but the sound of them was oddly familiar. He focused on it, chasing it through the fog in his mind, following the faint rise and fall of conversation.

Then came the first clear sensation. A cool, steady pressure against his cheek.

Not sharp. Not cold like the Black Tide had been. This was solid, grounding, a thumb brushing along his skin with a patience that felt out of place in the dark. The weight of it wasn't heavy, but it stayed, as though unwilling to leave him alone in the empty space.

The voices shifted. One of them was softer now—a tone he recognized but couldn't name. Words came through in fragments.

"…Black Tide… exposure… longer than anyone should've…"

Another voice answered, composed.

"…he'll survive this."

Something about those words reached him in a way nothing else had. Not the meaning, but the voice. It settled somewhere deep, pulling at a part of him that had forgotten what it was like to feel anchored to anything.

His head barely moved, but the instinct to lean into the touch was there. The hand paused, then shifted, careful not to break the contact. He didn’t know who it belonged to, only that it felt familiar in a way the dark did not.

More voices followed—another one lighter, warm with a kind of unguarded affection.

“Snowy’s dreaming.”

He would’ve smiled if his body remembered how.

The voices faded again. The hand stayed a little longer before it, too, slipped away.

And for a time, there was nothing.

Waking came in fragments.

Not all at once, but in slow, disjointed pieces—sounds before sensation, light before memory. The world beyond his body felt distant, like a room glimpsed through thick glass, voices dulled by water.

Someone was speaking again.

He recognized the cadence before the words, a soft, steady tone like a familiar lullaby half-remembered from childhood. The voice belonged to someone kind. A presence that had lingered at the edge of his awareness for what felt like days now.

“…the elder’s boy finally agreed to eat this morning,” she was murmuring, more to the room than to him. “I told his father you’d be annoyed if you woke and found out they’d starved themselves waiting.”

The words drifted over him like a current he couldn’t quite swim to. It should have been easy to open his eyes, but the weight behind them was too heavy. Limbs ached in distant, dull waves. His mouth was dry. He could

sense the faint pull of linens against his skin, the sharp herbal scent of something cooling nearby.

At least he was still here.

Some part of him almost found that surprising.

The voice—Hyacine, his mind finally supplied—went on, her words blurring in and out of focus. She was fond of speaking to the room when she thought no one was listening. Not to fill the silence, but as if the act of saying something gentle aloud could keep the cold at bay a little longer.

His memories came in scattered flashes. Smoke. Blood. Distant cries. The grip of the Black Tide's corruption sinking its teeth into him after days spent too deep in its reach. He'd stayed too long. He remembered the faces of the refugees he'd led back, their relief when Okhema's walls finally came into view. Then nothing.

He wasn't dead.

Yet.

The air shifted. A cool cloth against his brow. The quiet scrape of water in a basin. The subtle sound of Hyacine's voice as she worked, recounting inconsequential things—a harvest late in the outer fields, a stubborn soldier refusing rest, Tribbie sneaking honeyed figs from the kitchens. Not a litany of grief or prayers for deliverance, but simple, living details. As though to remind them both that the world went on.

The haze in his mind lightened, though his body still refused him.

Of course, Phainon thought dryly. Leave it to me to survive in the most inconvenient way possible.

He held on to the sound of her voice, letting it tether him to the here and now. It didn't matter what she said. It was the constancy of it that filled the room—a warmth against the cold weight of his own stillness.

And for the first time in what felt like days, the quiet didn’t feel quite so heavy.

He’d started piecing things together.

Not quickly, but gradually—like the slow drip of water filling a cracked basin. In the haze between waking and sleep, between pain and numbness, voices had come and gone. Some sharper, some tender, others leaving no more than an impression.

The most frequent was Tribbie.

He could always tell when it was her. Light footsteps, a too-quick shuffle, the faintest rustle of paper or fabric as she smuggled in whatever sweet she thought would coax him back to himself. She never spoke for long. Just short, scattered bursts of one-sided conversation. Worries dressed up as nonsense. Calling him Snowy. Promising to save him a candied plum. Once, she’d said *We miss you when you’re not awake, you know.* And then promptly knocked something over and scurried out again.

He was fairly certain he owed her a new tray.

Aglaea came too, less often. Her voice was unmistakable—unhurried, words weighed and precise as if each carried the heft of a promise. She never stayed long, but when she did, he caught snatches of her speaking to Hyacine. Brief reports, orders, a quiet assurance that Okhema’s people hadn’t lost faith. That the Deliverer was merely tending to grave matters. *Better that they believe you vanished on some higher errand than think you’re fading in a sickbed. He’d have to thank her for that*.

Eventually.

And then… there was the other voice.

Less frequent than the rest. It was familiar in a way that tugged at him, though his fogged mind refused to settle on the memory. It didn’t linger like the others. When it came, it stayed only long enough to mark its presence

and vanish again—leaving the room colder, or warmer, or heavier, he couldn’t tell which.

It was there again now.

The soft creak of a door. The muted scrape of boots against stone.

Hyacine’s voice lifted, bright with something akin to relief.

“Lord Mydei. Welcome back.”

He didn’t need to see to know the shape of the presence that entered.

Some part of him went still, waiting.

Footsteps, deliberate but unhurried, crossed the room. The faint clink of iron at a hip. The sound of a chair being pulled closer to the bedside.

“I wasn’t expecting you again so soon,” Hyacine spoke softly, a smile in her words. “The way you’ve been moving between Kremnos and here, I’m not sure when you find the time to breathe.”

A pause. The rustle of cloth as someone sat.

“I breathe when I must,” came the

reply. “And I’m told Okhema still stands.”

Hyacine gave a soft chuckle. “It does, thanks to a few stubborn warriors.” Her tone gentled again, edged with something fonder. “I’d hoped you’d sleep before coming here, but I doubt anyone could’ve stopped you.”

Another silence stretched, this one easier. Phainon let the voices roll over him, shapes and sounds threading into familiarity. He could feel the air shift as that presence moved closer, the faint coolness of it brushing his skin.

“How is he?” the voice asked, lower this time.

Hyacine’s answer came with the calm cadence of a healer who’d said these words often.

“Stronger than he was. No fever today. Breathing steady, though shallow. No sign of waking… yet.” A pause. “He hears us, I think. Or feels when someone’s near. It’s hard to say. But he fights.”

A rough, dry humor itched at the edge of Phainon’s mind. He would’ve liked to throw something irreverent in just then—some cutting remark about Mydei’s persistence, about how he must be growing fond of the Deliverer if he kept making these trips.

But the thought lost its edge as soon as it formed.

It didn’t feel quite so funny anymore.

Hyacine hummed, then the clink of glass on wood followed.

“I’ll fetch new linens. And more of those herbs Tribbie keeps insisting on. Call if he stirs.”

Another soft sound of movement, and her presence drifted away.

Phainon waited.

The room settled again, quiet save for the steady pulse of the wind outside.

A hand brushed his wrist—careful, cold with the bite of metal, though gentler than it had any right to be.

“…Deliv—” the voice started, then corrected itself. “Phainon.”

Another breath.

“How are you?”

A question without expectation.

And though both of them knew no answer would come, it was asked anyway.

Mydei spoke again. Not for anyone else's ears.

"The Tide's holding." He started with. "I reclaimed the eastern ridge three days back. Nothing I couldn't manage."

A sigh, long and measured.

"Okhema looks the same. The wind's colder." A faint scrape as he adjusted in the chair. "It felt strange walking these streets without you."

Another pause, quieter now.

"You'd complain about the market stalls being crooked. Say the guards were slouching. Threaten to throw me in the river if I left before breakfast."

The corner of Phainon's mouth almost twitched at that. Almost.

"I can't say I missed your complaining," Mydei added, tone dry but softer than anything anyone else had likely ever heard from him.

Fingers brushed his wrist again, steady, anchoring.

"I'll… stay a while."

And he did.

After that there was a soft, near-silent hum. Not a melody, but something close—a thread of sound that settled into the room without disturbing it.

The brush of fingers through his hair was unexpected. Gauntlet-clad, though careful—too careful, like handling something fragile. As if Mydei thought he might break if touched wrong. Which was absurd, considering the state of him was already well past wreckage.

And then something cool pressed just above his ear. Light. Metallic. Fixed in place with the kind of precision only a soldier or a priest would bother

with.

A pin?

Phainon’s sluggish mind circled the thought, trying to conjure a shape, a guess. He didn’t wear pins. Not his style. Nobody pinned anything to his head unless it was a blade aimed to split it.

But Mydei wasn’t one for empty gestures.

His voice came again, quiet enough that it felt like a thought pressed just behind Phainon’s temple.

“Olives are for the living. Victory waits for you, fool.”

There it was—the familiar edge, affection folded so tightly into the insult it was nearly invisible. Nearly.

Phainon strained, willing his eyes to open. It hurt, sharp and useless, but he tried anyway. A dull sound escaped him for the effort—part groan, part frustrated curse.

His thoughts fumbled through the pieces, trying to fit the weight and shape of what little he’d been given. Olives. A pin. His hair.

Was it…?

No. Couldn’t be. If memory serves right, in Kremnos those things didn’t get handed out like spare coins in the street. Not to anyone but blood-kin or—

Or.

A wreath pin. An olive one, if Mydei’s words weren’t just decorative nonsense. Iron, by the feel. Gods.

Kephale’s mercy, was that actually what it was?

Was Mydei… being sweet?

He didn’t even have the energy to be properly scandalized. Or to laugh at how utterly predictable it was that it’d be Mydei who’d manage to turn a battle token into a quietly unbearable act of tenderness.

If he ever managed to open his cursed eyes again, Phainon was going to have to live with the knowledge that the God of Strife—his God of Strife—had pinned an olive wreath in his hair like some fool romantic out of an old epic.

And gods help him.

He didn’t hate it.

The soft click of the door marked Mydei’s leaving, but the warmth he left behind refused to follow.

Lightness came back in pieces.

The distant world had sharpened into clearer sounds, though his eyelids still felt weighed with stone. The burn in his throat dulled to a scratch. Even the ache in his limbs now throbbed in steady, manageable pulses—background noise to the small, quiet world that had gathered around him.

At some point, soft fingers carded absently through his hair.

Phainon would’ve startled if his body had any interest in cooperating. As it was, he lay there while someone hummed a low, tuneless melody under their breath. The sensation was… oddly nice. Gentle, careful. A little bit of warmth in a body still too cold.

“See? I told you it was soft,” a voice teased—Hyacine, unmistakably.

A lighter, brighter laugh followed. Tribbie.

“It’s like snow, but it grows,” Tribbie announced with the solemnity of ancient wisdom. “We approve.”

“Good thing he’s not awake to hear you. I can only imagine what sort of nonsense he’d say back.” Hyacine gave a little huff, teasing.

Phainon might’ve made a theatrically snide remark about their bold assumptions, but it didn’t quite reach his lips. Still, it was strange how the sound of them filled the room, settling in the air like sunlight through a half-cracked window.

Bits of conversation came and went, sometimes light, sometimes trivial. Talk of the market square reopening, of some merchant’s absurd claim to have Black Tide-proof boots. A ridiculous rumor about Aglaea threatening a councilman into silence. Phainon let the words wash over him, surprised at how steady the room felt.

Tribbie’s voice piped up after a stretch of quiet, her hands fiddling with something by his bedside. “We should go soon. She says it’s rest time,” she muttered, likely meaning Hyacine.

“Mm. One more thing,” Tribbie whispered, leaning in close enough that Phainon could feel the warmth of her breath near his ear. “He doesn’t say it, but De’s really worried.”

His chest tightened—a quiet, involuntary reaction that surprised even him.

Tribbie’s small fingers pressed something into his palm. A light, papery object, no larger than a coin. It settled there as if it belonged.

“For luck,” she said simply. A pause. “Get better soon, Snowy.”

He heard the patter of her steps retreat, the door creaking softly open and shut.

Hyacine sighed in mock exasperation. “You spoil him, you know.”

“Can’t help it,” Tribbie chirped from the hall. “He’s our Snowy.”

Another chuckle, a fading sound, and then it was quiet again.

Phainon, still pinned in aching stillness, let his awareness settle around the little charm in his palm and the warmth left behind by company worth the keeping.

The next visit came not long after.

Hyacine had left again, muttering something about a shattered leg and a reckless apprentice healer.

Phainon felt the shift before he heard it—a heaviness in the air, the faint scent of iron and storm-lit salt. Mydei. He didn’t need to see him to know it by now.

But this time, the King of Kremnos didn’t immediately move closer. He lingered near the door, as if debating his own right to be here.

Phainon, sharp despite his half-waking state, wondered at that.

Then another voice spoke, smooth as velvet stretched over something sharper.

“Mydeimos.”

A familiar name spoken in a tone only one person would dare use here.

Aglaea.

That explains it.

Phainon could almost picture the tilt of her head, that unreadable, knowing smile she always wore like armor.

“Lady Aglaea,” Mydei answered, his voice losing some of its usual rigidity.

Aglaea’s footsteps moved further into the room, a measured glide. “You’ve been back twice today,” she remarked lightly, though the words carried an undertone like drawn silk. “A little uncharacteristic for the famed God of Strife, isn’t it?”

“I… owe him that much,” Mydei replied stiffly.

Aglaea hummed, neither agreement nor reproach. “Mm.”

Another pause stretched long between them, before Mydei spoke again. “I… do not fight as well without him.”

The admission hung in the room like a drawn breath.

Aglaea didn’t respond right away. She didn’t need to. The weight of her gaze—Phainon could almost feel it from across the room—said everything.

Phainon almost winced on Mydei’s behalf.

When she did speak, it was in that peculiar way of hers, words woven like half-prophecy, half-curse. “Some victories belong to two hands,” she said softly. “And some wars are not meant to be waged alone.”

She wasn’t wrong.

Aglaea’s footsteps receded without another word.

The door shut.

For a long moment, there was only the hush of the room, and the faint rasp of Mydei’s breath.

Then, with a sigh, Mydei crossed the room and sat down on the edge of the bed, the weight of him familiar now.

Phainon would’ve given anything to see the look on his face just then.

And maybe to throw something at him for being this hopeless.

If only his damn arms worked.

He stayed like that a while until Mydei spoke.

“I stopped by the western cliffs,” Mydei’s voice came, quieter than usual, as though speaking to a room that wasn’t meant to answer. “They’re still standing.”

A beat.

“I don’t know why I bother checking.”

Another pause. He wasn’t in any rush.

Phainon cracked his eyes open, just barely, a slit of blurred shapes and light. It stung. Enough to remind him he was still tethered to something. The figure nearby was indistinct, but the silhouette was unmistakable—tall, composed—

And in his hand, something small caught what little light managed to slip through the room. Pale, glassy blue. Or close to it.

“I found this near the old temple walls,” Mydei said, as though continuing a conversation they hadn’t started. “There’s nothing left out there. Barely any ground worth walking on. But this… it was just lying in the sand.”

A subtle shift of armor, and then Mydei was closer, placing something cool and impossibly smooth against Phainon’s chest, just where his collarbone met his heart.

“Sea-glass. Used to carry them for impossible odds.” A faint scoff. “You’d appreciate the irony.”

Phainon tried to focus on it—the weight, the shape, anything—but it was little more than a ghost of a sensation. He caught the faint glint of blue again before his eyes slipped shut. Even through the haze, he could picture it. A bead, glass rounded soft by years of tide, kept in old Kremnoan pockets for impossible survival.

He supposed it figured. Mydei, stubborn, impossible man that he was, would bring him something like that.

“You’re still ahead,” Mydei muttered, a little rough now, the words meant for neither of them.

Phainon wanted to answer. Something cutting, something to break the heaviness of it—maybe a crack about how next Mydei would be writing him poems—but the thought lodged in his throat.

He gave up trying.

All he could do was lie there, with the sea-glass pressing a promise against his skin, and the realization that he couldn’t say anything as Mydei pinned a fragment of impossible survival to him like some half-forgotten talisman.

Hopeless. Absolutely hopeless.

It wasn’t much, but it stayed with him.

It happened on some unremarkable day. No sharp turning point, no divine crack in the sky, just a slow, quiet easing back into the world.

Phainon stirred beneath the weight of sleep, though sleep hadn’t felt restful in weeks. The light no longer stung so violently behind his eyes. It came to him in gradients this time—dim and pale, the blurred shape of walls, the drift of pale curtains, the familiar vaulted ceiling of Hyacine’s infirmary. Air moved soft against his skin. He could smell herbs steeping somewhere nearby, bitter and sharp, mixed with old wood and something floral.

And a voice. Low, melodic. Humming.

It took a moment to place it. He didn’t startle—the return of sight wasn’t some grand epiphany, more like a steady lifting of fog. And there, seated by his side, was Aglaea. Her head tilted, golden hair catching the afternoon light, humming to herself like it meant nothing.

When his eyes dragged open, blurry but steady, she stilled.

A soft, wry curve touched her mouth. “Ah,” she murmured, voice rich and effortless, “so the Deliverer chooses to rejoin us after all.”

She watched him for a moment longer, head still slightly tilted, then let out a quiet, almost amused hum.

“Had I known all it took to wake you was boredom,” she remarked, voice lilting and dry, “I’d have hummed louder days ago.”

A faint chuckle followed. She reached out, adjusting a stray lock of his white hair as if to tuck it neatly behind his ear—though it didn’t stay.

Her tone shifted then, losing its playful edge but retaining its softness. “You’ve been asleep for nearly two weeks,” she murmured. “The corruption’s lost its hold, though you’re weaker than I’ve ever seen you. Your core holds steady, but it flickers more than it should. Hyacine says your mind’s the last thing to settle.”

She rose, smoothing the front of her pale robes, and gave a small, unhurried smile. “I hope you get better soon, Phainon. Okhema has gone quieter without you.”

Without waiting for a reply, she turned for the door. “I’ll fetch Hyacine. She’ll be insufferably pleased.”

And then she was gone.

It was late when the door opened. The hour hung heavy, thick with the kind of hush that made footsteps sound louder than they should. Phainon, eyes half-lidded against the dim glow of the infirmary’s ever-burning lanterns, caught who it was as he crossed the threshold.

He didn’t know why he did it.

Somewhere between instinct and impulse, he let his eyes slip fully closed and his breath slow, feigning the shallow cadence of sleep. It wasn’t spite,

or petulance, or even a game. It was… something else. Maybe cowardice. He didn’t know. He didn’t care to untangle it.

But he felt Mydei’s approach—a steadiness in the air, a pull like some ancient tide finding shore.

And so he lay there, unseeing, unmoving, waiting for whatever came next.

Phainon felt the pause before anything was said—the way Mydei’s gaze lingered over him, the faint shift of weight as he stepped closer. The air settled differently in the room when he was near, heavier somehow, though not unwelcome. He could almost picture the way the other man’s brow might be furrowed now, searching for signs of wakefulness.

A soft exhale, and then Mydei’s voice, faintly perplexed, half to himself.

“Hyacine said you were awake earlier.” A pause. “Strange.”

Phainon might’ve smirked if he dared.

Another beat, then the scrape of a hand over his jaw—the sound of someone tired in his bones. “Well… you must be asleep.”

There was a sigh, the kind a man only let slip when he thought no one was listening. A subtle shift as Mydei leaned back against the wall, as if even sitting felt like a concession.

A muttered admission, so soft it might’ve been mistaken for the creak of old stone.

“I… don’t sleep well when you’re like this.”

Phainon felt something twist uncomfortably in his chest—a warmth he didn’t ask for.

He kept his eyes closed.

Phainon lay still, feeling every measured shift of Mydei’s weight as the God of Strife lingered longer than usual. It was almost funny, in a bleak, tired

sort of way, how a man like him could feel so uncertain in a room with no one conscious to judge him.

Then, finally, there came the faint scuff of leather against the floor as Mydei moved. Not toward the door.

Toward him.

Another rustle—the soft tug of something thin and coarse being unwound from where it had been tucked away. Phainon could feel it, the ghost of the motion, as something looped gently around his wrist. The fibers were rough, but the touch was careful. Reverent.

Ash-twine.

An old Kremnoan knot, the kind bound between soldiers before long battles. A promise of survival. A tether to bring them home.

“You’re going to live,” Mydei stated. “Whether you like it or not.”

The knot tightened with a final, decisive pull, then Mydei’s hand lingered against his skin for a moment longer than it had any right to.

Phainon might’ve teased him for it, if he could. If he could even trust his voice not to crack around the quiet ache of it.

There was a shift again—the shadow of Mydei leaning in closer. The faint scent of old steel, salt, and woodsmoke catching in the air between them. Then the press of a mouth, cool and steady, against his forehead. The kind of touch made for farewells on battlefields, or the unspoken things left behind in the dark.

Phainon’s fingers twitched.

A small thing. A flicker of will against an otherwise uncooperative body. But enough.

Mydei drew back just slightly, breath catching, and then he was brushing a stray lock of pale hair from Phainon’s face—the rough edge of a gauntlet

tracing briefly against his temple.

He said nothing.

Didn’t acknowledge it. Didn’t curse him for stubbornly pretending to sleep. Just let the moment settle.

And then, without another word, he straightened, pausing at the door as if wanting to stay a little longer before steeling himself and turning.

When he left, it was before dawn—or whatever passed for it in Okhema—the shadows still stretched long and uneasy across the infirmary walls.

He lay there, the coarse twine biting faintly against his skin, and wondered what kind of idiot went around leaving battlefield knots and forehead kisses for half-dead men. Apparently, his kind of idiot.

It was the quiet that woke him.

Not the ache in his limbs, or the stiffness in his throat, or even the stubborn pulse of a headache that hadn’t yet let go. Just the soft scrape of linen being folded, the muted clatter of glass against wood.

Phainon cracked one eye open to find Hyacine bustling around the infirmary, hair half-tucked behind one ear, humming faintly to herself. Morning light filtered through the old shutters.

His gaze drifted down to his wrist.

The ash-twine knot was still there, a rough little loop, its ends frayed slightly. It didn’t feel warm anymore, but the memory of it lingered.

“Ah,” Hyacine’s voice perked up when she caught him watching. She set down a bundle of gauze, coming to lean against the end of his cot with a bright, teasing smile. “So one of your little charms finally worked, did it?”

Phainon huffed a soundless breath through his nose, the closest thing to a laugh he could manage.

She reached down and tapped the knot gently. “Guess someone out there didn’t want you dead after all.”

If he could’ve, he might’ve had something clever to say. As it was, he just let his eyes drift shut again, not from weariness, but to soak in the small, ordinary calm of the moment.

It felt… manageable. For the first time in days.

Hyacine gave a satisfied little nod and moved back to her work.

The world didn’t stop for small mercies. But it was kind enough, sometimes, to let them linger.

It happened gradually.

The haze that had gripped his mind for days began to lift, slow as mist retreating before dawn. Thoughts came cleaner, no longer sticking together in clumsy, half-formed knots. The names of things returned. Faces, places. The weight of memory settled back into its rightful place.

He was stabilizing. At least in here.

His body, however, had other plans.

A dull ache beneath his skin pulsed to something sharp. Heat flushed his face, prickling uncomfortably, while his pulse lurched, quick and uneven. His breath hitched, shallow and ragged in his chest.

Phainon recognized the signs for what they were. A body’s clumsy attempt to reset itself after too long at the edge. He wasn’t dying. Not yet. Not again.

To anyone else, though, it wouldn’t look that way.

Sure enough—the clatter of hurried footsteps echoed down the corridor. Voices, raised and sharp. The scrape of a chair as someone stood too fast.

Hyacine’s voice, tight with alarm:

“Get the tonic. Now.”

Someone else murmured a prayer—familiar words meant for the stricken and the damned.

Phainon sighed, a shallow, rasping thing that scraped his throat.

Today’s going to be a long day.

And he was right.

The infirmary shifted.

What had been a quiet, dimly lit room of hushed visits and half-spoken hopes bristled into sudden motion. Hyacine barked an order to one of the assistants, her usually gentle voice sharp with strain. Someone bolted the doors. Linens were replaced, cool water fetched, the air thick with the scent of herbs meant for easing fevers.

It wasn’t panic. Not quite.

It was preparation—Okhema’s old habit of standing between its own and death when it came knocking.

Phainon could feel it in the way the room held its breath.

A new voice cut through the murmur. Low, calm, and clear as poured wine.

“Is it that bad?”

Aglaea.

She stepped inside with the grace of someone well-versed in the theater of deathbeds. No terror, no breaking voice—just somber understanding. The slight furrow between her brows was the closest thing to fear she’d allow herself.

Phainon, from the fog of his burning skin and rattling chest, managed a faint pulse of appreciation for her steady presence.

Tribbie darted in not long after, her eyes glossy and too-bright, a scrap of something clutched in both hands. She tiptoed close, carefully tucking the charm beneath his pillow.

“We’ll be back, Snowy,” she whispered, her voice wobbly with effort. “You stay. We like you here.”

And then she was gone—a streak of red hair and flickering light.

Phainon would’ve apologized for the worry he caused if his throat could’ve managed it.

As it was, he settled for the closest thing he could manage: a faint twitch at the corner of his mouth as he tried to speak, a soft, ragged sigh that might’ve been a laugh if you squinted.

Hyacine noticed. She shot to his side so fast a chair nearly toppled.

“Phainon?” her voice cracked. “Can you—?”

He managed a croak of sound. Something along the lines of *‘Relax. I’m not dying guys.’*

But all that came out was a hoarse, broken wheeze.

The color drained from Hyacine’s face. She clutched his hand tighter.

Phainon rolled his eyes at himself (way to go)—or tried to. It may have been a blink. Internally, the words still shaped themselves clear enough.

I’m fine. Stop fussing, I feel bad now.

But despite the heat pounding beneath his skin, despite the ache in his chest, there was no bitterness in the thought.

Just tired fondness for his companions who wouldn’t leave him be.

He heard the footsteps long before the door burst open. At first, it was a distant, hurried rhythm—another set of boots joining the frantic shuffle already filling the infirmary. Phainon barely registered it. Just another set of hands come to wring themselves uselessly, probably.

Then, the stride registered.

Even half-delirious, barely clinging to wakefulness, Phainon knew those steps. Crisp, impatient, precise even when rushed.

His stomach turned.

Oh no.

The door slammed open hard enough to rattle the hinges.

“Mydei,” someone breathed—an aide, or maybe Hyacine, he couldn’t tell.

And there he was.

God of Strife. King of Kremnos. Face pale beneath the set of his brow, pale hair clinging to his forehead from the humid Okhema air. Armor half-stripped, breath shallow like he’d run the entire length of the stronghold.

He crossed the room in three sharp strides, dropping to a knee beside Phainon’s bed.

“How is he?” The words cracked out of him like stone split under pressure.

An aide stammered a summary—fever worsening, pulse erratic, shallow breathing, body resisting treatment. The usual grim report.

Phainon, blinking sluggishly, watched from beneath half-lidded eyes.

Couldn’t help it. He thought: *Huh. Never seen him look like that.*

Mydei’s gaze swept over him, taking in the flush on his skin, the sheen of sweat on his temple, the uneven hitch in his breath. And then—as the aide

finished reciting what should’ve sounded like a death sentence—Mydei’s expression shifted.

A pause.

“Dying, you say?” he murmured, arching a brow.

He leaned a fraction closer, searching Phainon’s face.

“Yeah,” he muttered. “Looks real dead to me.”

It was dry. Barely a joke. But to Phainon, it might as well have been the funniest damn thing anyone had said all week. If only he could laugh without his ribs catching fire.

He swore Mydei almost smirked then, like he could feel the flicker of amusement in the room even without hearing it.

“Idiot,” Mydei muttered under his breath, voice barely audible as he sat back against the edge of the bed, scrubbing a hand over his face.

Phainon’s chest ached in a way that had nothing to do with fever.

The next few moments blurred together in the haze of low murmurs and hurried footfalls. Phainon lay motionless with Mydei languidly observing him, his pulse skittering uncomfortably against his ribs, breath coming too shallow. He was aware of the room shifting around him—aides bustling in and out again, the scent of medicinal herbs thickening the air—and then, Hyacine appeared at the door.

She looked exhausted. Hair slightly unkempt, eyes bruised with sleeplessness, voice stretched thin as she called out for supplies to be brought over. The calmness she usually carried like a lantern in the dark was still there, but it flickered now—brittle at the edges, propped up by sheer will.

When she saw Mydei sitting by Phainon’s bedside, her shoulders tensed even tighter.

“Mydeimos,” she started, her voice too steady to be natural. “I told you—”

“He’s fine,” Mydei said quietly, not looking up.

Hyacine’s lips thinned. “With respect, he’s not.”

Her eyes flicked to Phainon, to the fevered flush high on his cheeks, to the bead of sweat clinging to his brow. To the erratic rise and fall of his chest. The room was a knot of panic waiting to snap.

Phainon wished he could speak, even if it was only to tell them to stop fussing, that it wasn’t as bad as it looked. That his body was just slow to remember it was supposed to live. He managed nothing but a faint twitch of his fingers, unnoticed.

Mydei sighed.

Without fanfare, he reached for the heavy steel gauntlets he’d discarded earlier, the polished metal catching as he set it down carefully on the table beside the bed.

Phainon’s brow furrowed.

Wait.

Hyacine stared.

Mydei exhaled and braced his elbows on his knees, glancing down at Phainon like he was speaking to a stubborn subordinate refusing to follow orders. His voice stayed absentminded, though it carried the unmistakable weight of a vow.

“If you do not wake,” he murmured, “I swear upon Strife’s name, I’ll wear no steel again.”

The words dropped into the room like a stone into still water.

Even fever-hazed and half-cracked from exhaustion, Phainon’s sluggish mind processed it.

Wait, what?

Hyacine's eyes went wide, mouth parting slightly. She looked between them—between the gauntlets on the table and the uncharacteristic softness in Mydei's voice—and though she opened her mouth to protest, no words came.

That… calmed her. Not entirely, but enough. The panic in her features ebbed, leaving only bone-deep worry behind. She swallowed, gave a slow, shaky nod, and turned to busy herself at the side table without another word.

Phainon's pulse thudded unevenly in his ears, but it wasn't the fever anymore. He heard the dull clatter of metal as those gauntlets—those *gauntlets*—hit the table beside him, and for a moment, his mind genuinely failed to process what had just happened.

Wait.

Wait.

No fucking way.

Had his throat not felt scraped raw, he might've let out a disbelieving noise. Might've said something caustic and sharp and half a shade too fond. Instead, all he could manage was the tight, startled squeeze of his chest.

He didn't just—

He wanted to open his eyes—to glare at him, to laugh at him, to hit him for saying something so absurdly heavy like it was nothing. But his body wouldn't cooperate, leaving him pinned beneath the weight of that promise.

He felt a flicker of panic, bright and uninvited, followed by something sharper, meaner.

You absolute idiot. You can't say shit like that just to calm someone down.

His skin prickled. The knot of warmth that unfurled in his chest was not welcome, not now. Not like this.

For the first time in days, the room felt real. The hum of life around him, the scrape of Hyacine's hands gathering cloth and vials, Mydei's steady breathing—it all sharpened.

And Mydei, the bastard, just leaned back against the wall like he hadn't just sworn something half a god would hesitate to utter.

Phainon's gaze, heavy-lidded though it was, dragged to the gauntlets lying there.

I cannot believe you.

And yet, here they were.

At some point, Hyacine's stubborn vigilance buckled. She'd fought it for hours, worn to threads, but even a heart as steady as hers had limits. Mydei caught the moment her shoulders slumped, saw the fine tremble in her fingers as she fumbled with a clean cloth.

"Hyacine," he frowned.

She stiffened, tried to shake her head, but one of the older aides gently touched her elbow. A look passed between them—one of quiet understanding—and finally, she let herself be led to the next room.

"I'll… I'll be right back," she promised.

Mydei didn't answer.

The door shut soft behind her, leaving a hush in its wake. Only the gentle scrape and the far-off murmur of Okhema's evening prayers carried through the walls.

Phainon, still pinned to the bed by fever and exhaustion, registered it distantly. The shift in the room's air, the less frantic pace.

A rough, calloused hand took his.

Mydei’s thumb traced the back of his hand, idle.

“Still causing trouble,” Mydei muttered.. “Even now.”

Phainon’s heart tugged hard in his chest.

It was strange, that something so small could steady him better than any fever balm or prayer. The ache behind his eyes, the weight in his limbs—it all felt a little less sharp.

Mydei didn’t speak after that. Just kept his hand in Phainon’s, a quiet vigil in the dark.

And before long, the warmth of it blurred into sleep. Phainon’s frayed awareness tugged him under once more, but this time, with the ghost of that touch lingering like a promise.

Morning came quietly.

Not with the warm gold of dawn—as per usual, but with a soft, cool gray that settled over the city like a held breath. The infirmary lay in a rare hush. No hurried footsteps, no distant clatter of basins, no soft calls between healers. Just the gentle, steady flicker and distant hum of wind against stone.

Phainon woke with a start.

His body jerked as though from a long fall, a sharp gasp dragging in through cracked lips. For a terrifying moment, he braced for the familiar nausea, the ache that had made even breath a labor these past days. But it didn’t come.

His head spun—but gently, like a tide retreating instead of crashing.

He lay there a moment, blinking up at the low, wooden ceiling, waiting for his vision to swim. It didn’t. The lines of the beams held steady. The pale

curtain to his left barely stirred. His chest ached, ribs tight, but his lungs pulled air. His limbs felt stiff and sore, but they listened when he willed them to move.

Slowly, gingerly, he lifted one hand, flexed his fingers. The motion burned, muscles protesting like stiff leather, but the fact he could feel that resistance at all brought a raw, fierce relief.

Gods. He could move.

His other hand followed, pushing against the thin blanket, and he managed to prop himself onto his elbows. His hair, flattened by sweat and sleep, clung to his brow, but for the first time in what felt like eternity, his body belonged to him again.

The room was empty.

Just him.

He let himself savor it for a breath.

Then, his gaze drifted toward the side table.

A faint frown pulled at his brow.

The gauntlets were gone.

Where they'd sat—weighty, impossible things, steel gleaming even in half-light—the table lay bare save for a folded cloth and a cup of cold water. Phainon stared, heart giving a confused lurch.

He'd known Mydei hadn't meant to leave them forever, only until he'd neared waken up. Gods, he'd wagered whole fragments of his half-conscious humor on the sheer absurdity of it. Strife didn't shed steel without cause. But seeing the empty space struck deeper than he liked.

Maybe because he hadn't gotten to see him take them.

Maybe because some part of him had wanted to wake with them still there.

Phainon swallowed hard against the sudden knot in his throat.

It didn’t matter. He was awake now. The fight hadn’t claimed him.

And judging by the quiet emptiness of the room—it was time to rise.

A soft knock rapped against the doorframe.

Phainon startled, breath hitching, and turned his head. It wasn’t much—his neck protested the motion, muscles stiff and reluctant—but it was enough to catch the slender figure lingering in the entryway.

An aide. One of Hyacine’s, if the loose pale robes and faint scent of herbs clinging to him meant anything. Young, with tired eyes and a nervous edge that said he wasn’t used to rooms like this. Deathbeds. Godwalking war heroes barely tethered to life. He hovered like a man uncertain whether to approach or flee.

“Well,” Phainon rasped, trying to go for friendly but coming off as annoyed unintentionally, “don’t just stand there.”

The aide jumped, color blotching high on his cheekbones. “Ah—Deliverer. You’re… awake.” He cleared his throat, schooling his expression, and stepped inside. “I… Hyacine said to check on you if you stirred. No one expected you’d be up this soon.”

Phainon managed a crooked half-smile. “Neither did I.”

The aide busied himself a moment, murmuring something about water and pulse checks, though Phainon waved off most of it. His hands still trembled when he moved them, but the ache was distant now, a dull background to sharper things. Like the awareness of air that didn’t burn in his lungs, of steady light, of the thin stretch of sky he could see through the window.

The aide fussed briefly, fingers cold against Phainon’s wrist as he checked the thrum of his pulse. Whatever he found seemed satisfactory—or perhaps the young man simply didn’t have the nerve to argue—because after a moment, he stepped back.

“I was told…” The aide hesitated, glancing toward the side table, then down at something he clutched awkwardly in his hand. “To give you this.”

Phainon blinked, watching as the aide crossed the short distance and set something carefully upon the bedside table. A small, palm-sized bundle, wrapped in simple cloth.

“No message,” the aide added, with a ghost of a smile. “Only said it was yours.”

Phainon frowned, brow furrowing. “From who?”

The aide just gave a look—one of those exasperated little glances that spoke volumes. *Who else.*

Phainon’s throat tightened.

The aide gave a respectful incline of his head. “I’ll let Hyacine know you’re awake. She’ll want to see you.”

And then, without waiting for protest or question, the young man was gone, leaving the door half-ajar and the soft hush of morning folding back in.

Phainon waited until the footsteps faded down the hall before reaching out. His fingers were clumsy, still stiff with disuse, but he managed to tug the cloth open.

A small, roughly carved ring of sea-glass slid into his palm.

Weathered smooth by salt and time, a pale, translucent shade of blue that caught the light like water. It was imperfect, edges uneven, the glass worn down by the sea until it yielded to shape. There was no embellishment. No symbol. Just the thing itself—quiet, unassuming, and unmistakably deliberate.

Phainon stared at it, his chest a mess of something sharp and unsteady.

Gods above.

Because he knew what this was.

A talisman for impossible survival. And when one man gave it to another…

His thumb brushed over the glass.

You reckless, impossible fool.

His lips tugged into a helpless, disbelieving smile. It felt foreign on his face, but he didn’t fight it.

And for the first time in weeks, Phainon felt something unspoken settle steady in his chest.

He turned the ring once in his palm, then, with slow, careful fingers, slid it onto his middle finger.

It fit.

The infirmary was still quiet, the sky still gray, but somehow the world felt a fraction lighter.

End Notes

I realized I physically don’t have the time to finish the original prompt I had in mind for day 7 (It was meant to be Demiurge Phainon with the concept of “What happens when a lord Ravager falls for you?”) since I made it way too lore deep (It’s like an alternative universe with Emanator Mydei as well), so instead I’ve been doing something else for day 7 in hopes of completing the original concept as a separate fic for another day.

Wish me luck in finishing it in time now, started yesterday morning and am like 3-4k words deep in it :’)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!